

FINGERSPELLING - A MINDFUL APPROACH



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Fingerspelling - A Mindful Approach

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A Note on Organization

You will notice that I tend to favor the Socratic method of teaching: a lesson, followed by practices and questions for consideration. This is done to stimulate introspection and engage our mindful muscles which are foremost in skill development and embodying the full spectrum of American Sign Language. You will see these questions included in “Mindful Practices.”

For years I mulled the idea of offering a text on fingerspelling, asking myself the question—what can I offer that is not already circulating? *The answer is an intuitive and mindful approach which has served me in my own professional development.* You will see exercises in this book which focus on settling the heart and mind of the student so you can begin the best practice session of your learning career. There are also plenty of fingerspelling related exercises what I have coined “Restricted Sets.” Restricted Sets correlate with the lessons and are words that you will see commonly fingerspelled. It’s been a pet-peeve of mine to see much fingerspelling course material using words that are not commonly fingerspelled, meaning you will rarely if ever see these words coming off someone’s hand or need to produce the word yourself. Certain combinations of English words are perhaps helpful in developing rhythm, speed, and flow but this can also be accomplished by using words that your average signer will see and experience as a fingerspelled word. Terminology is often fingerspelled, however, that is not the focus of this writing. All the Restricted Sets you see in this book are applicable in the real world of ASL communication and fingerspelling.

Please enjoy these lessons and the hopeful result of learning about yourself, your skill sets, and ways to explore with compassionate and fearlessness the improvement of your ASL work.

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

Introduction

Written April 14, 2020

If there's a guiding light for this book it's the wisdom of my first ASL Interpreting professor, Dr. Nancy Sheetz, who said to a room full of very nervous beginning Interpreting students, something like—fingerspelling is the first skill you learn and the last skill you perfect.

I remember letting go a huge sigh of relief and looking around the room, seeing similar release mirrored in my fingerspelling comrades. Dr. Sheetz exuded calm and poise. Large doe-like eyes pulled us into conversation and her exquisitely manicured nails in soft pink polish, articulated manually the art of fingerspelling.

I was an outdoor enthusiast at the time, whose hands often gripped the rough edges of rocks, trying to hang on and climb ever upward, so Dr. Sheetz was a different kind of role model for me. She was a C.O.D.A., Child of Deaf Adults, submersed in the Deaf experience as soon as she popped out of the womb. For all her polished looks, she was tough as nails, conveying the real-life scenarios of a sign language interpreter and the errors they sometimes tragically made. Often tucked among the joys and rigors of the profession were the stories of heartbreak due to preventable misinterpretation—interpreters who considered themselves competent only to later realize a grave mistake had been made, and for examples in that long ago class—the mistakes were fingerspelling—that first skill we had all learned as flailing beginners, but which would be the last skill (and I might add, *a continued skill*) to perfect.

Before we begin the perfecting, a bit of personal background may be beneficial to understand the methodology of this book. In addition to graduating from an Interpreting Training Program, I also graduated with a degree in Social Work. My interest in the workings of the mind, and specifically how the mind can be a sound companion, has always intrigued me. In the last ten years, I've practiced a way of life that has served my counseling work, my interpreting career, and my personal relationships. I believe this way of life can be applied to any situation with beneficial results—it's the practice of mindfulness.

For purposes of this writing, mindfulness is defined as awareness to what is going on inside and around us in the present moment. In my twenty plus years of interpreting experience, I have seen again and again, the pitfalls of failed communication, and typically misunderstandings revolved around two primary points 1) skill and 2) mindset. American Sign Language is a visceral, bodily experience that requires fine motor skills. The first thing that goes awry when we are upset, nervous or overwhelmed are our nervous systems—i.e. fine motor skills. We start doing all kinds of clumsy things of which can be seen very clearly in the intricacies of fingerspelling. So, to me, what seems foremost in providing a solid message delivery is a calm and stable presence. Mindfulness of body, feelings, state of mind and the environment can help form a foundational platform for ASL communication.

Here is a refreshing fact—anyone can practice mindfulness, or awareness, which is another word used interchangeably in this book. How am I so sure? Because your mind is always aware of something. Think about it, in this moment, you are hopefully immersed in these words, but if not, your mind might have wandered to needing a stretch or what's for dinner. Bringing our conscious attention to our hands, our bodies, the rhythm and flow of our fingers and the persons with whom we are communicating can have profound results in our communication.

Fingerspelling: A Mindful Approach will show us how to build a foundation of mindfulness and then ways of consciously and intentionally building our fingerspelling skills for the improvement of our ASL communication. Perhaps you are a professional ASL Interpreter, a student who simply loves ASL or any person, hearing or Deaf, who has within them the intuitive desire to communicate effectively. In the following pages we will tap into our innate desire and answer the question—how do we take a nuance of language, like fingerspelling, and with gentle persistent attention, strive toward clarity and understanding?

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: The Basics

[1.1: Instructions](#)

[1.2: Restricted Sets](#)

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1.1: Instructions

Why do we fingerspell? Why not just create a sign for everything and not worry about having to spell things out? Like English, the ASL manual alphabet is necessary for spelling proper nouns, names of people, places, and things in addition to short 3-5 letter words that are borrowed from the English language called loan signs. Loan signs make up much of our Restricted Set practice material and you'll become very familiar with them as the lessons proceed. Before we dive in, a few basics to keep in mind when you are fingerspelling:

- Apostrophes are signed with a twist of the “S” hand
- Double letters are just repeatedly fingerspelled with no special emphasis
- When faced with more than one word, pause slightly between words. For example, when fingerspelling a first and last name you pause in between so the names are distinct and don't run together.
- Acronyms are signed in small, controlled circles, to alert that this is not a word but letters that form an abbreviation
- Consider breaking longer words into smaller parts, it's both easier to sign and to understand. Doing so also helps to promote rhythm and flow. This is sometimes referred to as Phonetic Fingerspelling, and we will dive into more details for perfecting this skill in Lesson 8. For example, in RS #1: Jan-u-ary, Feb-ru-ary, Sept-em-ber, Oct-ob-er, Nov-em-ber, Dec-em-ber and so on.

Practice the bulleted fingerspelling basics as you proceed to Restricted Set #1 Calendar Months and Restricted Set #2 Holidays. The reason they are called “restricted” is because they form a subject category, that when kept in mind will provide a context for what may come off a partner's hand. If you know the Restricted Set is Months, you can be assured that twelve words will be fingerspelled and begin to anticipate the letters that may be coming. You could also utilize the process of elimination. Fingerspelling is a very active process and Restricted Sets enable us to engage our mindfulness to practice our anticipation skills and build confidence for success.

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1.2: Restricted Sets

RS 1 – Calendar Months

January

February

March

April

May

June

July

August

September

October

November

December

RS 2 – Holidays

4th of July

Ash Wednesday

Cinco de Mayo

Columbus Day

Dia de Los Muertos

Equinox

RS 2 – Holidays (page 2)

Father's Day

Good Friday

Ground Hog Day

Holi

Kwanzaa

Labor Day

Mardi Gras

Memorial Day

MLK Day

Mother's Day

Oktoberfest

Palm Sunday

Passover

President's Day

Rosh Hashanah

Solstice

St Pat's Day

Washington's Birthday

Yom Kippur

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Know Thyself

[2.1: Introduction](#)

[2.2: Mindful Practice](#)

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2.1: Introduction

As we begin this fingerspelling journey, we can take to heart Socrates words, “*To know thyself is the beginning of wisdom.*” What is your motivation for wanting to improve your fingerspelling skills? Is it that you tire of missing the lightning fast words flying off your Deaf friend’s hands while they giggle and poke fun? Are you sick of feeling the clutch in your gut when the word Saskatchewan comes up in conversation? Maybe you’re an awful speller and letters do a little dance in your head. There’s a common theme in almost all these examples—tension! We’ll get to talking about tension a bit later. But for now, let’s get to knowing thyself and spend some time with your motivation to improve your fingerspelling. There are two helpful perspectives that might drive your goals for this class:

1) Clarity – you may wish to improve your readability, smooth out the finger tangles. How do you do this?

Mindful Tip 1: *Consciously (i.e. mindfully) move your palm orientation to the side to naturally emphasize the shape of your letters.*

o Letters in which this can be done and still maintain conformity with ASL are: C, D, F, G, H, K, O, P, Q, X

- These 10 letters are almost 40% of the manual alphabet letters so...being mindful of your palm orientation is paramount to pull this off with success!

Why would you want to sign with the purpose of clarity or readability? Perhaps your goal is to be in the field of education or you work with children and they are just becoming familiar with the English language, or...perhaps you like to take it slow and chill when you’re chatting with your ASL using friends

2) Speed – you may wish to improve your ability to go fast. Now, before we go any further, here is a rule of thumb that brings us to another tip...

Mindful Tip 2: *Never, ever, ever, never compromise clarity for speed.*

Stop, please and say the italicized aloud to yourself three times. Never compromise clarity for speed can become a kind of mantra that each time you say it, waters the seeds of clarity in your beautiful brain!

Mindful Tip 3: *For speed, consciously (i.e. mindfully) keep your palm orientation always pointed outward.*

Palm facing out eliminates all movement and allows the hand to stay still, steady, and unmoving with no wasted effort. This translates to speed and ease of letters transitioning one to the other.

o Letters in which this can be done and still maintain conformity with ASL are same as the above: C, D, F, G, H, K, O, P, Q, X

- Again, much of the ASL manual alphabet can be signed with the palm orientation unmoving, however, clarity of each letter will go down.

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2.2: Mindful Practice

Mindful Practice 1

with the FAMA (Fingerspelling: A Mindful Approach) way of signing, you will always be encouraged to take an even breath and come back to your body. ASL is an entirely embodied process and it helps as foremost to be aware of what your hands are doing while finger spelling. Let's begin:

Body/Feeling

Practice all 26 letters of the manual alphabet for clarity, paying attention to palm orientation, then answer the following questions:

- Does signing for clarity feel natural?
- Can you feel how turning the wrist, even tiny movements slows the hand down?

Practice all 26 letters of the manual alphabet for speed, being mindful of palm remaining out, then answer the following questions:

- Does signing for speed feel natural?
- Can you feel how not turning the wrist enables your hand to move more

efficiently?

Mind/Environment

3. Think about your fingerspelling career, even if it's only a few hours old and answer the following questions:

- Of the letters: C, D, F, G, H, K, O, P, Q, X, which do you already sign for clarity?
- Which might be target letters that you may need to be more aware of signing for

clarity?

4. We should always keep in mind as foremost who we are signing with and what their level of competency and mental state are so we can adapt our hands for their success. An example of this might be, if our friend shows up and was in a near accident on the way to class, we may be inclined to give them a break and sign for clarity. This example can be extended to include a Deaf patient who just received a cancer diagnosis. Being mindful of such an impact, we would definitely want to fingerspell for clarity over speed.

- What population might benefit from fingerspelling with clarity in mind?
- Provide a hypothetical situation where you would be wise to fingerspell for clarity?
- Who population might benefit from fingerspelling with speed in mind?
- Provide a hypothetical situation where you would be wise to fingerspell for speed?
- Next time you struggle with a person's fingerspelling might it be useful to identify if they are fingerspelling for clarity or speed?

Mindful Practice 2

Practice expressive and receptive fingerspelling of RS #1 and #2 with a palm orientation of either Clarity or Speed.

Two Categories of Fingerspelling

Now that we can begin to understand our goal for clarity or for speed, we can look at two categories of fingerspelling that will break our personal motivation down even further.

- 1) Expressive fingerspelling - your ability to fingerspell. It's as simple as that.
- 2) Receptive fingerspelling - your ability to catch what another person has fingerspelled

As a beginning ASL student, tendency is to be able to generate the letters yourself better than you can comprehend what is coming off another person's hand. To reflect on this using our previous example, imagine catching the word Saskatchewan, especially if fingerspelled by a fluent signer. Um, probably near impossible. However, if Saskatchewan is your hometown (and you know how to spell it!) you would most likely successfully convey the word.

At some point in your ASL career a very glorious shift will most likely take place. You will begin noticing that you catch far more fingerspelling than you can fluently convey. Now, this isn't the case for everyone, but in my twenty plus years of teaching

experience, I see that it holds true for many. Why do I tell you this? So, you can understand which category is your weakness, expressive or receptive fingerspelling, and be cognizant if the shift happens. It's a benchmark towards fluency.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Know the Other

[3.1: Interbeing of Fingerspelling](#)

[3.2: Mindfulness Practice](#)

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3.1: Interbeing of Fingerspelling

There is an understanding when practicing mindfulness that will help us greatly in our ASL fingerspelling communication and it's the concept of interbeing. Interbeing is a term coined by Zen master, Thich Nhat Hanh, to describe the fact that we are interconnected with everything around us. His example is that when we look deeply at a flower, we can see the rain, the cloud, the soil...everything necessary for that flower to come into being. The same can be said of ASL—we come to the conversation with our current skill level and whatever else is going on for us that day and so does the other person. All these conditions make up the conversation we're about to have. Many times in my career, I have seen professional, competent interpreters pay zero attention to the needs of the Deaf consumer. I've seen students pay zero attention to the needs of their signing partner. Here's my point—good communicators are present for the ones with whom they're communicating. When we can be present for each other, great communication happens. We will know if what we fingerspelled was understood, if we need to sign for clarity or speed and in this chapter, we'll learn ways to help our communications flow more effortlessly. Now, we will address a few common questions that tend to be asked regarding fingerspelling etiquette:

How do I handle my mistakes?

It's instinct when we make a fingerspelling error to want to air erase it like it's some great catastrophe but think about what this does to the eyes. It's analogous to me making a verbal error and then wagging my tongue loudly for a few seconds. Respect the signing space, keep it clean and purposeful. Best way to handle fingerspelling mistakes is to just do an “eye blink,” a slight exaggerated blink to show that you have erred. If the word is short, 4 letters or so, begin again and sign it over. If it's a long word you can just back it up to the mistaken letter and keep going.

Being aware of the other is important when we make errors. If you make a fingerspelling blunder, ask yourself, did the person catch the word, in spite of the botch? If so, don't worry about identifying the error, just keep going. Think of it from the standpoint of mispronunciation, we don't always correct a verbal slip if our communication is still understood.

What if the person I'm signing with makes a fingerspelling error?

If you understand what is fingerspelled despite the error, just keep going. If you do not understand, interrupt with an attention-getting-hand-wave and sign “fingerspell” “again.” In this way, the entire conversation doesn't need to be repeated and conversation can continue to flow naturally.

Where should I look when watching someone else fingerspell?

Not at the hand! Does this come as a surprise? In signed conversation, fingerspelling or otherwise—we always wish to maintain eye contact. I learned this lesson the hard way, and it was never taught to me in my Interpreting Training Program, but by a professional colleague. I had received an offer to teach ASL at Lake Tahoe Community College, but before I accepted the position, I met with my Deaf team instructor who, after conversing for a spell, shared that I had to get over my habit of looking at her hand when she fingerspelled! She explained that in the time it takes to break eye contact and look at the hand, the fingerspelled word could be over and done with! So, when we look to the hand, we either 1) miss the fingerspelled word entirely or 2) the signer is forced to slow down, wait for the eye gaze transition and all of this interrupts the flow of conversation and impacts the message. Remember, too, that over 60% of ASL relies on facial expression to convey meaning, so, if we're breaking away, we'll miss all the emotive indicators.

Where should I place my hand?

The dominant hand is traditionally used to fingerspell, unless of course you have a physical limitation, then it's acceptable to use your non-dominant hand. The key is to maintain consistency and not bounce back and forth with your hand choice. Our signing partners will appreciate not having to play ping-pong! The hand should be just in front of the shoulder and a comfortable distance from the body at about 6-8 inches. Also, as is the cultural norm, we're looking at the eyes of the one whom we're communicating. If the person you sign with is struggling to read your fingerspelling for a variety of reasons, you can compassionately move your hand a bit closer to your face and make it easier on them. To do this, however, you must pay attention and know the needs of the other.

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3.2: Mindfulness Practice

take a pause, come back to your breathing, and embody your arms, hands, and fingers. Proceed with the intention to practice Knowing the Other by setting a date with a fingerspelling comrade. Practice the above handling of mistakes, sustaining eye contact and placement of the hand with RS #1 Months and RS #2 Holidays. Hopefully, there's a level of familiarity with these fingerspelled words so you can open your peripheral vision and more easily catch them receptively as you maintain eye contact. When you finish your practice session, answer the questions below:

Body/Feeling

1. Practicing the eyeblink can feel a little goofy at first. Were you able to handle mistakes by you and your partner with an eyeblink?
2. How did it feel to maintain eye contact with your partner for a sustained period? Was it natural? In hearing culture eye contact is not continually maintained so this fingerspelling habit may take time to develop as we remind ourselves to come back when our eyes break away.

Mind/Environment

1. Was the location of the hand off the shoulder maintained or was it adjusted to suit the needs of your partner?
2. What environments might it be important to ***always*** correct our fingerspelling errors?

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Loan Signs

[4.1: Introduction](#)

[4.2: Restricted Sets](#)

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4.1: Introduction

A key to mindful fingerspelling is having awareness of what words one might expect to see come off the hand. We discussed that proper nouns are fingerspelled—things such as brand names, cities, etc. Another classification of fingerspelled words are loan signs, or words borrowed from English. Loan signs are sometimes referred to as lexicalized signs, meaning they are typically short fingerspelled words whose combinations take on the shape of a sign. For the remainder of the lessons in FAMA, we will dedicate ourselves to these fingerspelled words, you will begin to feel the fluidity, and rhythm your hands will adopt and learn to identify the comprehensive shape the loan signs express.

Mindful Tip 4: *Know your vowels like the back of your hand (pun intended).*

Loan signs are generally 3-5 letters. Since every English word contains vowels—A, E, I, O or U always will be contained within the very short loan sign. Which leads us to our next tip.

Mindful Tip 5: *Practice catching the first and the last letters of every word.* There are two reasons:

- When vowels become comfortable, they begin appearing as an expectation
- First and last letters give you a point of focus and with vowels as the expectations for the middle, words begin to materialize

Mindful Tip 6: *Don't be afraid to drop letters.*

This may come as a big surprise but at the core is the idea that a combination of letters becomes a recognized sign for the word. Over the years of ASL lexicalization, letters were dropped for the purpose of ease and shape. Dropping letters is systematic, it's not randomly done. Assimilation is another way of describing this phenomenon, meaning that some letters will change their formation depending on surrounding letters. Typically, the dropping of letters does not happen until one becomes fluid and practiced at which point the body develops more ease, naturally adapting for speed by dropping letters. We will discuss and practice dropping letters in class as comfort with loan signs improves. So, let us put the above mindful tips into practice and begin with RS #3 Loan Signs: Things Around the House.

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4.2: Restricted Sets

RS 3 Loan Signs: Things Around the Home

AC – air conditioning

apt - apartment

attic

ATV – all terrain vehicle

bag

barn

bills

boots

car

carpet

check

condo

cozy

deck

desk

duplex

film

fix

gas

glue

ice

jeans

junk

latch

loft

log

MWO – microwave oven

nail

nap

note

oven

pet

plastic

pool

porch

puzzle

rail

ref – refrigerator roof

rug

RV – recreational vehicle shed

sink

stove

tack

tape

toy

tool

truck

trunk

TV - television

yard

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

5: Configuration

[5.1: Introduction](#)

[5.2: Mindfulness Practice](#)

[5.3: Restricted sets](#)

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5.1: Introduction

I am presently sitting in my Tahoe Spring garden, looking around at all the emerging and new life popping up from the thawing ground. Anyone who has lived in Tahoe knows that our Spring is often intermixed with snow, sleet, freezing rain, and any mix of weather in between. When the Alpine sunshine finally shines strong, tiny emerging Snow Plants with their bright red asparagus like blossoms and green meadow seedlings push up and out. If you don't have the eye of awareness, it's often easy to miss our brief season before the explosion of summer heat. It's the same with the birds. I'm told by a bird-watching friend that Tahoe is one of the premier touch down places for all kinds of migrating birds, they stay briefly and find respite for their long journey ahead. Hummingbirds typically arrive in May along with the sweet cooing of the Mourning Doves and the bright orange of the Robins. If one's attention is not sharp, many of the seasonal and migrating feathered friends that grace our shores are entirely missed. All this talk of emergers, shapes and forms, colors and textures, bird song and the visitation of species are a metaphor for configuration in Fingerspelling.

Simply put, configuration is the shape of a fingerspelled word. Some words, by nature of the letters, will have obvious shape, for example, the loan sign, "cozy." Then there are other words, like the name "Sam," that have almost zero shape and are very difficult for the eye to catch. It's the difference between a tiny Spring seedling and a blooming, in-your-face sunflower. Or, the sharp pip of the Olive Flycatcher as it's passing through amidst the squawk of the everyday Jay. configuration is the word's character, shape, and form. If we aren't careful, we can beat ourselves up with self-criticism, berating ourselves—why am I not catching fingerspelling today? What's wrong with me? When really, it could be that the word fingerspelled has very little configuration.

The more we can become familiar and comfortable with the letters of the ASL fingerspelled alphabet, the more successful we will become at identifying them, very similar to spotting the sprouting, growing life and the new winged arrivals. Again, we come back to mindfulness—being aware of what is going on inside and around us in the present moment.

Train your brain to identify shape (configuration) with a particular letter as you would identifying a leaf, cluster of pine needles, the call of a bird or flash of color and shape of a wing pattern in the sky. It takes time, it takes patience and it takes awareness.

So, let's dive in and consider a few mindful tips and then begin practicing with configuration.

Mindful Tip 7: *Be attentive to letters that have a great deal of shape change and ones that have very little shape change.*

Configuration varies if the word is being signed for speed, but as a general rule the following holds true:

- B, C, D, F, G, H, I, J, K, L, O, P, Q, R, U, V, W, Y and Z have strong configuration. Almost 75% of the manual alphabet has shape change. Doesn't it make sense? More configuration means more ease in communicating your ideas. ASL is a visual, gestural language, so of course, handshapes were developed to reflect this innate desire to communicate quickly and efficiently.
- A, E, M, N, S, T, X have very little configuration, or shape. A bit over 25% of the manual alphabet has no shape. An approach may be, to practice and study these very diligently, it's only 7 letters.

Mindful Tip 8: *Memorize shortcuts and assimilations.*

In Lesson 4 we learned that letters are often dropped or blended when fingerspelling loan signs. The letters that dropped or blended are of course, the ones with no shape! Why have them there if they don't add anything to the visual picture? Here are a few shortcut letters, which change when the specific letter is influenced by the letters around it.

- Shortcut E – When the letter before E uses two fingers (index and middle), the E is often in a short-cut position. For example, with the following loan signs, a short-cut E is implemented:

o Stove, oven (notice how the hand can more easily slide from V, to shortcut E, to N, which also requires the movement of the same two fingers)

*It's best to allow the shortcut E to develop naturally along with your speed and efficiency. Don't try too hard to perfect this, just be mindful that when you're practicing receptive skills, you may see the shortcut E coming off your partner's hand—don't let it throw you!

- Hand J vs Wrist J – A shortcut J, using only your hand, very small and controlled, will be much more efficient. Remember, it won't have as much configuration as a loopy, wristy J, but it will allow you to save energy, move into the surrounding letters easier and be speedier, if this is your goal.

Mindful Tip 9: Anatomy is everything!

Analyze the nature of your hand and your partner's hand. Long, slender fingers generally form tighter letters, well, because they can reach the positions with ease, vs short, beefier fingers which tend to be more open and relaxed. Long fingers = tight letters and short fingers = open letters are a generality, of course, but when we're mindful, then we can identify patterns and with awareness, have greater receptive success.

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5.2: Mindfulness Practice

embody your arms, hands, and fingers. Proceed with the intention to practice being mindful of configuration with RS #4 Foods/Preparation. The goal is to build a level of familiarity with these fingerspelled words so you can open your peripheral vision, focus on feeling the shape as you maintain eye contact during receptive practice. When you finish your practice session, answer the questions below:

Body/Feeling

1. Practice the 19 letters that possess a high degree of configuration. Which letters do you make open and loose? Which letters do you make tight?
2. Practice the 7 letters with a low degree of configuration. Which letters do you make open and loose? Which letters do you make tight?
3. What's the size of your hand? What's the length of your fingers?
4. Which are your favorite letters to make? Which are your least favorite?

Mind/Environment

5. As a warm-up for receptive fingerspelling partner practice, get in the habit of analyzing the hands of those with whom you're communicating with. Are their fingers long and slender, meaning they may have tighter handshapes? Or perhaps their fingers are short and squat, meaning they may be more open and loose in formation of letters. Also, what level of signing is your partner? If they're fluent, their letters will most likely be very relaxed regardless of their hand's structure because they have had exposure to the language. As beginners, we tend to have much tension in the hands, but as we become more comfortable with ASL we relax our postures. The same can be said of spoken languages, as we gain experience and exposure, we relax our accents and become more natural in our pronunciations. Being mindful of all these environmental factors before you begin practice will give your mind a point of focus and increase your success when you know what to expect.

Half-way Benchmark

Let's do our second timed recording to have a comparison to the timed recording on page 5. We're only half-way through this manual, but I suspect you've made some gentle gains. If not—no fear, we have five lessons left to improve and grow. We'll use the same familiar phrase below since it incorporates all letters of the alphabet:

The Quick Brown Fox Jumps Over the Lazy Dog.

Set a timer for one minute and sign the above sentence as clearly and concisely as possible during that one-minute window. Remember our rules, however.

1. If you make an error, go back to the word (not the whole sentence) and fingerspell that word again and keep going.
2. Assign each word in the sentence a number so you can be exact in your end calculation. For example:

The = 1 Quick = 2 Brown = 3 Fox = 4 Jumps = 5 Over = 6 The = 7 Lazy = 8 Dog = 9

If my timer goes off, and I completed one full sentence and was on "fox", I give myself a score of 1.4. If I'm faster than that, and I get three full sentences fingerspelled, but when the timer went off, I was signing "over", I get a 3.6. Does this make sense?

3. Whatever word you're on when the timer goes off, be kind to yourself and give yourself the full word.
4. In the same spirit of kindness, we will do the 1-minute recordings two times, just in case you bumble, fumble one of them.

Record your highest score and compare to page 5.

Ready, set, begin! Date _____ High Score _____

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5.3: Restricted sets

RS 4 Loan Signs: Foods/Preparations

Avo (Avocado)

BBQ

beef

berry

beets

broccoli

cauliflower

celery

coconut

corn

couscous

chips

cream

cucumber

diet

fry

gas

grapefruit

grill

ham

herbs

hummus

ice

jelly

juice

kiwi

lentils

lime

mayo

mango

mustard

oil

olive oil

organic

pear
pizza
plum
poach
pork
quinoa
radish
raspberry
raw
recipe
relish
rice
salsa
snack
soy
spicy
squash
taco
tofu
yogurt

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

6: Context

[6.1: Introduction](#)

[6.2: Mindfulness Practice](#)

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6.1: Introduction

Often when teaching Fingerspelling, I repeatedly remind students, “Fingerspelling is a very active process, having very little to do with the actual letters!” The active process I’m referring to involves being 100% mindful of the topic of conversation, i.e. what are we talking about? When we know the context, then we know what to expect when the fingerspelling pops up. For example, if I’m signing about being outside in my garden and planting seeds, then suddenly fingerspell a word, you should be expecting a vegetable loan sign (from RS 4). If you aren’t paying attention to what we’re conversing about and fingerspelling pops up, you may very well freeze, clutch, ask for repetition and still not catch what’s being communicated. Meanwhile, I leave you to go tend my garden!

Spending much time in the field of communication, where my sole job is listening to everything said and then interpreting the meaning into ASL, I see many obstacles to communicating that often don’t involve language errors but rather the inability to be fully present. In ASL communication there is one behavior that shows our partners are paying attention:

- Eye contact – we spoke of eye contact in Lesson 3, and this new communication habit takes practice. When one is around Deaf communicators for any length of time, it’s noticed the difference between hearing and Deaf culture. Hearing culture tends towards multi-tasking while Deaf culture necessitates eye contact for communication and visual attunement. Multi-tasking is tough to do if we use our eyes for only one thing—the person in front of us. As an aside, many Deaf friends over the years have joked about the “hearies” habit of being distracted by sounds and looking around continuously. In a Deaf experience, distracting sounds are often nonexistent and so, it’s far easier to visually attune without anything else competing for attention.

I realize I’m on a bit of a soap box here but in this age of multi-tasking, technology-pulling culture, it can be very unusual to keep our minds focused on one thing and one thing only—the conversation at hand. Mindfulness plays an enormous role in successfully utilizing context to understand the fingerspelling of my partner. Full, one hundred percent awareness of the other is a huge ingredient for success.

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6.2: Mindfulness Practice

Breathe and Smile Receptive – put away all distractions, focusing on the context of RS 3 and RS 4. Construct 10 ASL sentences, 5 with RS Things Around the House as the topic of conversation and 5 with RS 4 Foods and Preparation as the topic of conversation. Include a related Fingerspelled loan sign in each appropriate sentence. Practice your sentences throughout the week until they are fluid and smooth without any hitches, embodying all fingerspelling habits learned in Lessons 1-5, then proceed to the following:

1. Find a partner who has done the same Lesson 6 Mindfulness Practice 1
2. Put aside all distractions and focus on maintaining good fingerspelling habits learned in Lessons 1-5
3. Remember your context of conversation – Things Around the House and Foods and

Preparation. Take turns signing one ASL sentence at a time, incorporating the appropriate loan sign with clarity or speed and concentrating on fluidity and ease. Your partner fingerspells only the loan sign back to you as confirmation that they understood your fingerspelling.

4. When your mind wanders, because it will, bring it back to the topic of conversation, eye contact, breathing and smiling.

When you complete the above practice, answer the following questions:

1. What distractions did you notice?
2. How present were you on a scale of 1 – 10 (1 being not very present, 10 being fully present)
3. Did you maintain eye contact or fall back on the habit of looking at the hand?
4. What prevented you from being present?
5. How many of the 10 loan signs were you able to catch?

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

7: Closure

[7.1: Introduction](#)

[7.2: Mindfulness Practice](#)

[7.3: Restricted Sets](#)

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7.1: Introduction

Now we're going to discuss closure, which means filling in missing information to make sense of a fingerspelled word. I have a personal story to share that encapsulates this important skill. Very early in my interpreting career, I received an assignment to team interpret a conference. It was a doozy with over a thousand people in attendance. My team partner had taken the lead in arranging everything, she was also my mentor as I was just getting into the profession, so I let her figure out details and trusted I was ready for my first "platform" interpreting assignment, also called stage interpreting.

I showed up after completing a fairly long drive to get there on top of navigating my way to the actual auditorium inside a large convention center. Having never maneuvered a massive venue, I had underestimated the time all of this would take and ended up arriving minutes before the Deaf presenter was to go on stage as the opening speaker. If this were an interpreting class, I would emphasize rule number one for mindful and professional interpreting—always show up as early as possible so you can be poised, calm, gathered and ready to go. So, here is a bit of foreshadowing—a late arrival. Next, when I asked my team interpreter for a program, she mentioned someone was bringing us one, but she hadn't received it yet. This nightmare evening occurred only a few years after the internet was invented, when very few people had cell phones, let alone data plans.

So, here we were: no agenda, no program, no speaker notes, with just a bit of a context for the evening's material, and what did my team partner decide to do—have me start! You can see that this is quickly going downhill. I felt guilty for having arrived late, so I agreed! Standing behind curtain, the Deaf gentleman handed me the microphone and out we walked onto the stage, my first stage, mind you. He began by saying, "Hello, my name is...."

I, being nervous, had no lag time whatsoever, I was right on his tail, and voiced, "Hello, my name is...." And then there's this long, dreadful, eternal pause. You probably know what happened, I missed his fingerspelled name, entirely! In my nervous, self-absorbed state, I didn't even catch enough to make a guess, and who wants to guess the keynote speaker's name when everyone (but me) knows what it is! I looked to my team for support, and my stomach fell—she hadn't caught his name either. By now, this unrepresented gentleman was well into his speech, and me, the newbie interpreter was near panicked.

What's my point in sharing this story? Never voice, "Hello, my name is...." until you comprehend the speaker's name! If you never catch the name, you can proceed into his speech without an introduction and it's unlikely to have horrible ramifications. After all, the crowd is probably holding the treasured program and can figure out who is speaking. Closure involves a little faith; it involves actively deducing.

Here's a written example of how we practice closure all the time—It's summertime, hot and I am parched. I've been on the beach all day, and when I walk into the store and go to the produce section, I see the rind of a green and white circular fruit on ice. I think, aaaahh, yes, w_t_rm_lon! Did you catch the word in spite of the gaps? If you did, you made closure.

The more we practice fingerspelling, the more we can make closure quite effortlessly. If, we go back to my nightmare-platform-interpreting-experience and mindfully observe the man was identified as a white Caucasian male in his 60's—what if we saw these names fingerspelled:

Rich__d

Ge_rg_

Fr__k

Can we fill in the missing information with a degree of confidence? We know that vowels constitute many of the letters in a word so we can start there, kind of like playing hangman when we were kids. If we are mindful, observant, and aware of our topic of conversation, closure becomes almost second nature. Let's practice closure with our next category of Loan signs, RS 5: Technology and Measures.

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7.2: Mindfulness Practice

Firstly, take a pause from reading and peek at RS 5 at the end of this lesson. Now answer the following what ifs:

1. If I was talking about taking my tiny 4-week-old kitten, to the vet, and he was placed on a scale, and then I fingerspelled, what might the word be (refer to Technology, Science and Measure)?
2. I mention a new business venture and tell you to check it out, then I fingerspell, w_b_it_. What is the word?
3. An IT guru lists programs on his computer: Adobe, Photoshop, and Illustrator. Then he references these three and signs a word that you miss. What word might it possibly be?
4. Your friend excitedly reports over the weekend they ran a marathon but didn't complete it, then they signed 18_il_s. Guesses?
5. Because you've been studying (and hopefully memorizing) RS 3 and RS 4 we'll use these as our next examples for using context to make closure—I sign to you that I'm going to Round Table, then in my hunger, my fingerspelling goes delirious. What did I probably fingerspell?
6. You're having a bad fingerspelling day. A kitchen remodel is being discussed with all kinds of fingerspelling that you missed. What are at least three likelihoods after making closure?
7. Preparing an egg for breakfast is discussed but you miss the fingerspelled word, p__che_. what's your guess?
8. A closet cleanout is discussed with a bunch of things going to Goodwill, but you missed the fingerspelling. Possibilities?
9. I talk about going to my friend's farm and helping her paint her bar_.
10. A friend complains about monthly b_ll_, especially the increase in r_nt!

These may seem easy, but here's the reality—the above is typically how we see fluent fingerspelling, it's very, very rare that you will see every single letter, unless of course you are a beginning fingerspelling student who is meticulously accenting each letter. The articulation of each letter brings us to the next lesson. Until we arrive at Lesson 8, take a deep breath, smile, and consider how you might incorporate closure into your fingerspelling methodology. My story at the start of this lesson, offers insight that can serve in many life lessons, and here are takeaways—

Mindful Tip 10: *Adopt an attitude of focusing on what you catch versus what you miss.*

Mindfulness allows us to be aware of what's going on inside and around us so we can calm, soothe, breath and continue, knowing that we are not machines, we are human beings, and we are capable of paying attention and trusting our skills.

Mindful Tip 11: *Practice composure so you can make closure.*

I cannot stress enough how composure will save the day. Fingerspelling is a skill involving fine motor dexterity and a calm nervous system. Breathing in, I'm aware that I am fingerspelling; Breathing out, I smile, filling in gaps accurately and to the best of my ability.

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7.3: Restricted Sets

RS 5 Loan Signs: Technology, Science and Measures

acre

app

backup

cell

cm - centimeter

DVD

DVR

data

DNA

email

foot

fax

FB – Facebook inch

IT – Information Technologies lab

lbs – pounds

media

mile

min – minute mode

MP3

mph

oz – ounces

password

sec - seconds

software

RS 5 Loan Signs: Technology, Science and Measures (page 2)

TTY (Tele-Text Typewriter)

ton

USB

VRS (Video Remote Service)

VRI (Video Remote Interpreting) website

RS 6 Loan Signs: Cities and States

CA

CC – Carson City

GV – Gardnerville
IV – Incline Village
KB - King's Beach
LA – Los Angeles
LT – Lake Tahoe Minden
NV
PV – Placerville
Reno
Sac - Sacramento
SF -San Francisco
SLT – South Lake Tahoe
USA
(Most States)

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

8: Fingerspelling Phonetically

[8.1: Introduction](#)

[8.2: Mindfulness Practice](#)

[8.3: Restricted Sets](#)

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8.1: Introduction

Do you know studies show that the human brain can only retain about seven letters, words, or numbers at a time before it becomes overloaded and loses the entire string? Think about times when you tried retaining phone numbers and the challenges the nine digits presented. Our lack of retention for anything over seven letters is very important to keep in mind when practicing receptive fingerspelling because if there's more than seven letters the likelihood of understanding goes down. There's a technique that can be helpful, however, which brings us to our next Mindfulness Tip:

Mindful Tip 12: *Break fingerspelled words into syllables or chunks.*

Spelling phonetically aids comprehension so the word can be retained. For example, if I fingerspell H-Y-P-E-R-A-C-T-I-V-I-T-Y in thirteen individual, succinct letters it will be near impossible to catch, even for a Deaf person. But if I chunk it phonetically, by syllables: HY-PER-ACT-IV-ITY, it will be comprehended no problem. Why? Because letters are grouped in no more than three. Our brains then divide the word into five units versus thirteen letters.

We consider phonetic fingerspelling a tool for our expressive skills as well, for it's far easier to get rhythmic when we're not stamping each individual letter, but rather, breaking the word into fluid parts. Spelling by syllables is extremely helpful for the signer and the person viewing the message and is a tool we utilize to ease comprehension on long words. We can practice phonetic fingerspelling with short words too, such as the Restricted Sets we've learned in this book. Here are a few examples:

Car-pet
Con-do
Plas-tic
Por-ch
St-ove
Pass-word

Our next Restricted Set 7: Body and Health is a very practical and concrete opportunity to practice and implement phonetic fingerspelling, for in real-world health situations we could be exposed to very lengthy medical terminology, where chunking becomes absolute necessity.

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8.2: Mindfulness Practice

Firstly, take a pause from reading to peek at RS 6 and RS 7 at the end of this lesson. Now, we're going to focus on creating practice sentences to do with a partner to purposefully practice fingerspelling phonetically.

- 1) Chose five loan signs from either RS 6 Body and Health or RS 7 Transportation.
- 2) Pair your fingerspelled word with another word that you determine (longer than seven letters) to create an ASL sentence.
 - Example: Recently, I visited Holly-wood blvd.
- 3) When you write out your sentences in ASL, be sure to hyphenate fingerspelled words phonetically at every opportunity.
- 4) Practice your five ASL sentences—fingerspelling phonetically—until the words roll with fluidity from your fingertips!
- 5) Now, find a partner who also did this lesson and practice signing and fingerspelling your five sentences, remembering to chunk at every opportunity.
- 6) How many of your partner's ten fingerspelled words did you catch?
- 7) Did you stamp? Or did you fluidly break up words?
- 8) Did you follow all the previous Mindfulness Tips? If not, which do you need to continue to practice?
- 9) What were other observations?

To close this lesson, here is a summation:

Mindful Tip 13: *Make a mindful commitment to end your days of stamping each individual letter!*

For any word with more than one syllable, practice implementing the strategy of phonetic fingerspelling. Your sign community will thank you!

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8.3: Restricted Sets

RS 7 Loan Signs: Body and Health

aid
ankle
back
blister
burn
cancer
COVID-19
CPR.
Dr.
drugs
EMT
ER
feet
flu
foot
HC - handicap
hip
hives
hyper
ID - identification
knee
leg
ouch
rash
rib
Rx
sick
sinus
sore
stiff
sunburn
toes
upset
wart

x-ray

RS 8 Loan Signs: Transportation and Location

ave – avenue

bank

blvd – boulevard

bus

cab

car

casino

club

co – company

concert

dept – department

gas

HS – high school

job

limo

lobby

mile

park

PO (post office)

rack

raft

ranch

resort

SUV – Sport Utility Vehicle

taxi

truck

tune up

valet

zoo

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

9: Emphatic Signs

[9.1: Introduction](#)

[9.2: Restricted Sets](#)

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9.1: Introduction

Empha...what?! Next up is emphatic loan signs, or fingerspelling loan signs that move for emphasis. Emphatic, or directional loan signs are a unique category of ASL Loan signs. Get ready, it's a little freaky because they move! Yes, after all this time of stressing the importance of keeping your hands still and not stamping, yada, yada, yada, we're going to move our fingerspelled words all through space! The movement is purposeful, however, it's not random. The decision to emphatically sign a loan sign is done similar to stressing a word or drawing out sounds.

To get us started practicing, below is an abbreviated list of emphatic loan signs with movement tips. Being mindful of your movements and practicing each emphatic sign until you develop muscle memory and fluidity will take time.

Mindful Tip 14: Expression and appropriate directional movement is vital when signing emphatic loan signs.

Below is a list of emphatic loan signs, categorized according to movement for ease of memorizing. There's an alphabetized list of RS 10 Emphatic/Directional Loan Signs, at the end of this chapter, coming right after RS 9 Miscellaneous Loan Signs. Before beginning to implement emphatic signs into your fingerspelling protocol, it's very important you see these modeled by a fluent signer so the freaky doesn't become incorrectly freakier! When you do see emphatic/directional loan signs modeled, please be mindful, take notes and study video of the movements so that these can become a resource in your fingerspelling toolkit. Successful execution of fingerspelled emphatic/directional signs is an indication of advanced understanding.

Moves in Downward Circle

busy

early

fun

easy

style

Moves Outward

cool

NG – No Good

oh

or

ouch

well

wow

Exaggerated Downward “p” Movement

oops

upset

One Letter Wiggles

hahahaha – palm up, “h” wiggles

if – “i” stays up, “f” wiggles

Touches Head Region

K.O. – Knock Out – from forehead down

PF – Pissed Off – “p” “o” from nose down, palm stays in

EEK! – from ears outward

Repeated Letter Movement

OK

so

Moves Towards Reference

all

back

Uncategorized Movement

what! – letter combination twists palm in

yes – letter sequence nods downward

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9.2: Restricted Sets

RS 9 Loan Signs: Miscellaneous

air

box

busy

cab

check

club

do

fog

fix

grand (son/daughter)

gross

icy

luck

mode

model

nap

news

note

off

on

or

OT - overtime

own

owner

PhD

rare

rent

rim

sale

sue

tack

tape

tax

wild

RS 10 Loan Signs: Emphatic/Directional

all

back

busy

cool

early

easy

EEK!

fun

hahahaha

if

K.O.

NG

oh

OK

oops

or

ouch

PF

so

style

upset

well

what!

wow

yes

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

10: Engagement

[10.1: Introduction](#)

[10.2: Mindfulness Practice](#)

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10.1: Introduction

As we wrap up, let's recall our definition of mindfulness—awareness of what is going on inside and around us in the present moment. Awareness of inside and around, has intertwined like a thread through Fingerspelling: A Mindful Approach.

As I write this last chapter, it feels metaphoric to reference the very historic time that surrounds this present moment—the COVID-19 pandemic. For the last three months, education and learning has been relegated to online. I'm sitting outside my home in Tahoe, California on my laptop, with a view of Mt. Tallac. Tufts of clouds float by while I contemplate the immediacy of our final topic—Engagement. Perhaps it's being on stay-at-home orders, but...engagement seems the most vital of topics so far! The old adage, "Practice makes perfect," is crucial to apply, and yet, in this world of pandemic, the ability to practice our skills has been challenged. I must say, even as a certified ASL interpreter, fluent in ASL, after over three months of social distancing, my skills have suffered. I'm aware, I feel it in the slight hesitancy to recall a sign or perhaps a bumble of a fingerspelled word. With mindfulness, I can notice the slipups and begin to formally set time aside to practice. Learning ASL takes discipline! If we think back to the introduction of this book we remember—fingerspelling is often the first skill you learn and the last skill you perfect. Another way to say this might be, fingerspelling is a skill in state of continuous flux. Studies show that to master any new skill, it needs to be practiced 10,000 hours. So, these 10 lessons are only the beginning.

Most students who find themselves in a fingerspelling class have found that they know just enough to be dangerous. By dangerous I mean that we have discovered a tool (fingerspelling) that enables us to express something we do not know how to sign, so we therefore spell it. However, the ideas and concepts tumbling around our heads, go far beyond a few manually spelled words. Fingerspelling is only a smidge of the visual ASL communication equation. So, what do we do? Firstly, take an American Sign Language class! Fingerspelling is in no way a substitute for signing. Then, having a few classes under your belt, you can be on the search for Deaf friends who will entertain your beginning skills. Engagement gives purpose to our learning and satisfies our innate desires to be effective communicators. This brings us to our last tip:

Mindful Tip 15: *To improve our fingerspelling skills (especially our receptive skills) we must engage.*

In the time of the pandemic, engagement means Facetime, ZOOM or maintaining social distancing by fingerspelling 6 feet away, no problem! There are also incredible fingerspelling websites out there, YouTube videos and even the ability to record yourself very effortlessly on your device and then come back a few days later and watch, seeing if you can catch your fingerspelled words. There's an App called, Marco Polo, that uses visual recording texts as a kind of walkie-talkie to your friends. But none of these, replace signing with a native signer, a Deaf person. One of the best uses of time in your ASL journey is to engage with the Deaf community and invest in friends and acquaintances. Resourcing the Deaf community is the best insurance for growing and mastering your ASL skills, beyond any class, beyond any manual.

I sincerely hope, Fingerspelling: A Mindful Approach provided you with practices that built a strong foundational platform for fingerspelling skill development, and most importantly offered tools to be aware and present for the treasured ones in your life.

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10.2: Mindfulness Practice

First Skill to Learn, Last Skill to Perfect

Let's do our last timed recording to compare our awesome improvement! We'll use the same familiar phrase below since it incorporates all letters of the alphabet:

The Quick Brown Fox Jumps Over the Lazy Dog.

Set a timer for one minute and sign the above sentence as clearly and concisely as possible during that one-minute window. Remember our rules, however.

- 1) If you make an error, go back to the word (not the whole sentence) and fingerspell that word again and keep going.
- 2) Assign each word in the sentence a number so you can be exact in your end calculation. For example:

The = 1

Quick = 2

Brown = 3

Fox = 4

Jumps = 5

Over = 6

The = 7

Lazy = 8

Dog = 9

If my timer goes off, and I completed one full sentence and was on "fox", I give myself a score of 1.4. If I'm faster than that, and I get three full sentences fingerspelled, but when the timer went off, I was signing "over", I get a 3.6. Does this make sense?

- 3) Whatever word you're on when the timer goes off, give yourself the full word.
- 4) Fingerspell the 1-minute recordings two times and record highest score below.

Ready, set, begin! Date_____ High Score_____

Page 21 Date_____ High Score_____

Page 5 Date_____ High Score_____

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